

CER-04 · CERTIFICATION HANDBOOK

Routes into PCI: standard, founding, honorary

What each route changes, what it never changes, and the one route that involves no examination at all

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PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.

AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

There are three public routes into PCI. The standard route is application, payment and examination. The founding route is an invitation-only cohort entered with a code that waives the fee and bundles membership, study and examination access — the examination itself is unchanged. The honorary route confers the designation Honorary Fellow (PCI) by board decision and requires no examination, awards no certification, and grants no post-nominal in the credential suite. This document states what each route changes and what no route changes.

— About this document

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Routes into PCI: standard, founding, honorary

In one paragraph. There are three public routes into PCI. The standard route is application, payment and examination. The founding route is an invitation-only cohort entered with a code that waives the fee and bundles membership, study and examination access — the examination itself is unchanged. The honorary route confers the designation Honorary Fellow (PCI) by board decision and requires no examination, awards no certification, and grants no post-nominal in the credential suite. This document states what each route changes and what no route changes.

Who this is for. Prospective candidates deciding how to enter; employers and sponsors funding a cohort; anyone who has been offered a founding code and wants to know what it is worth; and anyone considering an honorary nomination, for themselves or for someone else.

— 1. The one rule that survives every route

No route awards a credential without an examination. The standard route and the founding route both end in the same sitting, marked to the same standard. The honorary route does not end in a credential at all.

That sentence is the whole document in one line, and it is written first because the alternative is a reader who works it out in month three. A route changes **what you pay** and **how you were invited**. It never changes what you have to demonstrate.

— 2. The three public routes at a glance

	Standard	Founding	Honorary
Who may enter	Anyone meeting the eligibility rule	Invited holders of a valid founding code	Anyone may apply; the board decides
Examination required	Yes	Yes	No
What is awarded on success	PCL-AI, PFL-AI or PML-AI	The same credential, on the same terms	The designation Honorary Fellow (PCI)
Eligibility rule	Three years, any field	Three years, any field, self-declared with evidence	Distinguished contribution, judged by the board
What you pay	The examination fee	Waived by the code, within its window	No examination fee, because there is no examination
Who decides	Assessment, then the certification decision	Assessment, then the certification decision	The board
Post-nominal in the credential suite	Yes	Yes	No

— 3. The standard route

3.1 What it is

Apply online, meet the eligibility rule of three years' professional experience in any field, satisfy the booking conditions, pay the examination fee, book inside your window, sit under proctoring, and earn the credential by passing.

3.2 What it costs

A single examination fee in US dollars, which opens a scheduling window rather than buying a credential. Fees are route-dependent and discountable, and the amount that binds you is the amount shown at checkout. The figure itself — including an unresolved conflict between two published amounts — is owned by [CER-05](#) §4, together with the window, refunds and retakes.

3.3 Why it is the reference route

Every other route is described by how it differs from this one. If you are reading a claim about PCI certification and cannot tell which route it describes, assume the standard route and check.

— 4. The founding route

4.1 What it is

An **invitation-only founding cohort**, entered with a valid founding code. One code grants **membership, study access and examination access together**: a full fee waiver layered over the standard flow, valid inside the window set on the code.

4.2 What it changes

Money and access, and nothing else. A founding candidate:

- declares the same eligibility — three years of professional experience in any field — and supports the declaration with evidence at the point of application;
- sits the same examination, of the same duration, marked to the same standard;
- receives the same credential, with the same validity, subject to the same recertification obligation.

Founding applications are reviewed. An application is recorded as approved or pending review, and may be rejected or, later, revoked. Approval of a founding application is approval of entry to the cohort — not of the credential.

4.3 What it does not change

A founding candidate is not certified by being founding. The credential is still earned by passing the examination. Nothing about founding status confers a result, softens a mark, or shortens a requirement.

4.4 Availability

The founding cohort exists inside a defined window. **[CONFIRM: whether the founding-route window is currently open and the date on which it closes]** — check the current published position before planning around it, and do not assume a code you were sent last quarter is still live.

4.5 Why the Institute runs a founding route at all

PCI interpretation. A founding-stage certification body needs candidates before it has a track record, and candidates need a reason to go first. The founding route pays for that asymmetry with a fee waiver rather than with a lowered standard, because a lowered standard would devalue the credential of exactly the people who took the risk. Founding candidates are the cohort with the strongest interest in the examination being hard.

5. The honorary route

5.1 State it plainly

The honorary route requires no examination. It confers the designation **Honorary Fellow (PCI)** — a board-conferred recognition of distinguished contribution to the discipline. It does **not** award PCL-AI, PFL-AI or PML-AI. An honorary award is recorded separately from examined credentials, under its own award reference series, precisely so that the two can never be confused by a reader, an employer or a verification check.

5.2 How it works

Anyone may apply; the board reviews and decides. An application asks for your professional history, qualifications, certifications and a summary of the contribution being put forward, with supporting documents. The decision is the board's, and the citation — the board's stated reason — is recorded with the award and shown on verification.

An honorary award is **revocable**. It can be withdrawn for cause, and the record shows when and why.

5.3 What it is not

- It is **not a certification**. No examination has been passed, so no assessed competence is attested.
- It is **not a post-nominal in the credential suite**. An honorary recipient does not write PCL-AI, PFL-AI or PML-AI after their name.
- It is **not a membership grade**. Membership grades — Student Member (SPCI), Associate Member (APCI), Professional Member (MPCI) and Fellow (FPCI) — are a separate ladder governed by membership rules. Whether an honorary award interacts with a membership grade is a membership question, not a certification one, and this handbook does not decide it.

5.4 Describing an honorary award honestly

If you hold one, describe it as what it is: an honorary recognition conferred by the Institute's board. Do not describe it as certification, do not list it among certifications on a professional profile, and do not let a reader infer an examination that did not happen. The Institute records honorary awards separately for the same reason.

— 6. The administrative routes

The platform also supports routes that are not marketed as public entry points but exist because real programmes need them: a **sponsored** route where a third party funds the candidate, a **complimentary** route, **full** and **partial fee waivers**, and a non-public **test** route used for platform verification.

Every one of them is a **billing arrangement**. They determine who pays and how much. None alters eligibility, the examination, the pass standard, the certification decision or the recertification obligation. A candidate entered under a sponsorship sits exactly the examination a self-funding candidate sits.

Two consequences worth stating for employers:

1. **Sponsorship buys an attempt, not an outcome.** A sponsoring organisation is buying its people the opportunity to be assessed. If it needs a guaranteed number of passes, it is buying the wrong thing from the wrong kind of body.
2. **The certification decision is not the sponsor's.** The credential belongs to the individual, and the assessment result is theirs. A sponsor is not a party to the certification decision.

— 7. How this goes wrong

- **Assuming honorary is a fast route to the credential.** It is not a route to the credential at all. §5.1.
- **Listing an honorary designation among certifications.** It reads as a certification the holder does not have, and it is the kind of error a hostile reader finds first. §5.4.
- **Treating a founding code as a certificate.** A code grants access. Nothing else. §4.3.
- **Letting a founding code's window lapse.** The waiver lives inside a window; the window closes whether or not you booked. §4.4.
- **Sponsors expecting influence over the result.** §6.
- **Comparing route fees without checking route conditions.** A waiver bundled with membership and study access is not the same product as a discount on an examination fee, and the two do not compare on price alone.

— Related

- [CER-01 – Certification handbook – master](#) — the full journey once you have chosen a route

- [CER-02 – The credential suite: PCL-AI, PFL-AI, PML-AI](#) — which credential you are entering for
- [CER-03 – Eligibility, application and reasonable adjustments](#) — the eligibility rule that every route shares
- [CER-05 – Booking, fees, rescheduling and cancellation](#) — what each route actually costs, and when

— Sources and standards

- PCI platform route records, founding-application records and honorary-award records, verified August 2026 — including the deliberate separation of honorary awards from issued credentials in the data model.
- PCI Publication Framework, [CANONICAL-FACTS.md](#) §5, August 2026.

— Status and version

Founding-stage document · Version 1.0 — effective date to be confirmed · draft · Reviewed under PCI governance. PCI makes no claims of accreditation or recognition beyond what is true today.